decision-making about covert operations. ‘This is because we don’t acknowledge our failures and never highlight our achievements,’ said Madhav Anand. ‘But we have been troubled for quite some time because our meticulous reports, prepared on the basis of spectacular intelligence, rarely get a response from the decision makers. We don’t know why, but one thing is certain: there is tremendous institutional bias against the R&AW and on several occasions, it has been the victim of misinformation. For example, R&AW never operates inside the country and never interferes with domestic issues, but politicians are always scared of the agency. I would like to make it clear that gossip about rivalry over internal intelligence is not correct. We could disagree with the IB or the Defence Intelligence Agency (DIA) on some issues but that is like friendly banter.’

According to Sethi, the only time R&AW officers are genuinely perturbed by the bureaucracy is when there are unnecessary obstructions by civilian officers at times of great urgency. For instance, Sethi added, suppose a certain situation in Nepal was hot and the agency needed to urgently move a unit from Myanmar to Nepal. In such a situation, bureaucratic obstructions and questions about expenditure are major roadblocks. Mobile units simply don’t have freedom to move from one place to another, said Sethi.

The bureaucrats don’t understand the perils and dangers of covert operations, said Rita. Spies have no legal backing and yet they must operate in hostile territory. ‘You are on your own if you are caught. This is not an easy life. You not only need to cultivate assets but also a network of informers. There is always a risk of failure while running an intelligence operation and vulnerability due to possible double agents. It requires great